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The current guidance on testing parameters for Artificial Intelligence (AI) remains vague. While efforts have been made to ensure that tests for AI systems exist, there is limited clarity on how many iterations of such tests are considered sufficient or appropriate.

An illustrative reference is the MEASURE function within the NIST AI Risk Management Framework (AI RMF) Playbook (Ref: NIST AI RMF Playbook – MEASURE). The MEASURE guidelines emphasize that "appropriate methods and metrics are identified and applied." However, they do not specify what constitutes a "good" metric or measurement in practical terms.

This ambiguity creates a gap: for example, an organization may interpret a single test iteration as being equally valid as 1,000 iterations. In the absence of baseline expectations or benchmarking guidance, such interpretations can lead to inconsistent validation of AI behavior and performance.

Although prescribing exact measurements or thresholds may not be feasible, additional guidance on the expected range or consistency of outcomes—such as statistical accuracy over a number of iterations, or acceptable variance margins—would be valuable. Providing feedback mechanisms or example cases would help organizations determine whether the scope and depth of their AI testing is sufficient to account for system variability and risk.

Some suggested actions to correct this gap include:

### **1. Establish Baseline Testing Thresholds by Use Case Risk Tiering**

Introduce tiered testing expectations based on the AI system's risk profile (e.g., low, medium, high impact). High-risk systems (e.g., healthcare, criminal justice) would be expected to undergo significantly more rigorous and repeated testing than low-risk systems (e.g., content recommendations). This follows principles already used in other regulatory contexts.

### **2. Incorporate Confidence Interval Guidelines**

Define minimum statistical confidence levels for test results. For instance, testing should continue until performance metrics (e.g., accuracy, fairness, drift detection) reach a 95% confidence interval with less than X% variance across iterations. This moves the guidance from number of tests to quality and consistency of outcomes.

### 3. Create Reference Benchmarks and Validation Sets

Develop and publish standardized benchmark datasets and test cases for common AI domains (e.g., NLP, computer vision). By using these, organizations can compare performance metrics and testing volume against peer implementations.

### 4. Define Testing Adequacy Through Convergence Criteria

Set thresholds for when further testing provides diminishing returns. For example, if after N iterations the model's performance variance is less than a defined epsilon (e.g.,  $\pm 0.5\%$ ), testing can be considered adequate. This gives a dynamic and adaptive stop condition.

### 5. Require Reporting on Test Iteration Justification

Organizations should be required to document and justify the number of test iterations performed, including rationale for stopping. This could be part of their AI assurance or risk management documentation. The focus is less on mandating a number and more on making the reasoning transparent and reviewable.

### 6. NIST-Led Industry Collaboration for Domain-Specific Testing Protocols

NIST can lead cross-sector working groups to develop domain-specific testing recommendations, including minimum test iteration ranges, acceptable variance limits, and tailored metrics. This collaborative model would ensure practicality while maintaining rigor.

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